mortality intervened once again when Wajahat succumbed to heart disease in December 1945. ‘He could thus be relied upon to prove a loyal colleague. My hopes and anticipations were amply fulfilled, but unfortunately, Wajahat fell a victim to heart disease during the middle of his tenure.’[20] The other Deputy Governor, C.R. Trevor was the bank’s Chief Accountant whom Deshmukh described as ‘a most pleasant and competent colleague.’

On July 24, the Governor General cabled the Secretary of State, L.S. Amery, seeking his approval. This was received on August 9 and the government order appointing Deshmukh as Governor and Wajahat Hussain and C. R. Trevor as Deputy Governors was issued on August 10, 1943. Deshmukh gave full credit to the support of the Central Board of the bank spearheaded by Purshotamdas and B.M. Birla for his elevation to the post of the Governor. In an address to the Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics in 1948, he observed that with the resignation of the Congress Ministers in the Provinces and the absence of the Congress Party from the Legislatures, the Central Board of the RBI ‘remained the only elected or representative of custodians and trustees of India’s economic and monetary interests and the determination with which they successfully recommended the appointment of an Indian to the post of Governor…has never received adequate recognition.’[21] Deshmukh also gives much of the credit to Amery whose firm stand ultimately led to his appointment as Governor. Had it not been for his support, Deshmukh may not have become Governor despite the support of the Central Board. Referring to this episode, Deshmukh observed that his appointment was due to ‘the rare sense of fair play and statesmanship that the Secretary of State appears to have displayed.’ The Government of India were, according to Deshmukh, ‘more royalists than the King himself’[22] and at first opposed any suggestion to make him the Governor although he had been introduced to the bank with their approval.

On August 9, a day before this order was issued, the annual meeting of shareholders was held in Calcutta with Deshmukh presiding. At that meeting two shareholders, B.P. Khaitan and G.L. Mehta, inquired about the delay in the appointment of a new Governor. Since the matter concerned Deshmukh, he was understandably embarrassed and requested Purshotamdas to answer on behalf of the bank. This was the opportunity Purshotamdas was waiting for (indeed, had created), and the shareholders